from the Coromandel Coast took a train to the North of India. My destination was more than 2000 km away, and was to be my first encounter with the vastness of my motherland.

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hrough the window of the compartment, I watched the countryside slip past. From a distance, the men in the fields in their white dhotis and turbans, and the womenfolk in bright

splashes of colour against the green background of paddy fields, seemed to inhabit some beautiful painting. I sat glued to the window. Almost everywhere, people were engaged in some activity which had a rhythm and tranquil ity about it—men driving cattle, women fetching water from streams. Occasional y, a child would appear and wave at the train.

It is astonishing how the landscape changes as one moves northwards. The rich and fertile plains of the river Ganga and its numerous tributaries have invited invasion, turmoil, and change. Around 1500 BC, fair-skinned Aryans